behind well-made roads, walled cities, temples and villas built of stone, brick and plaster, and nothing like them was seen again in Britain until after the Norman conquest seven centuries later. Similarly, in Northern India the urban brick-based culture that defined the Harappans was not to be seen again until the Indo-Iranian city of Taxila was laid out under Darius the Great in about 500 BCE.

What happened between those two dates remains to this day the most controversial question in Indian history.

In 1974 some Bhil peasant farmers from the village of Daimabad, sited on the Maharashtrian plateau some 45 kilometres north of Aurangabad, were digging up the roots of a dead tree for firewood when they made a remarkable find: a hoard of four cast bronzes. Three were in the form of animals standing on wheeled platforms: a rhinoceros, water buffalo and elephant. But it was the fourth item that caused all the excitement: a two-wheeled chariot drawn by a pair of yoked oxen complete with horns and exaggerated humps but with otherwise very equine bodies. Standing on the central pole is a small dog, and on the chariot itself is a naked man with a shaven head, holding a whip or reins. He stands just over 6 inches (16 centimetres) high and is portrayed realistically in every respect but one: his genital member (or possibly a sheath covering it) is erect and its tip divided to form a four-headed cobra. The Daimabad Charioteer very quickly became the subject of heated debate in academic circles.

The four bronzes had been uncovered beside a large mound on the left bank of an upper tributary of the Godavari River. The site had previously been excavated by the ASI but was immediately re-examined in an attempt to date the bronzes, which led to their being assigned to ‘the earliest phase of the Malwa occupation of this site’ (i.e. c. 1600-1400 BCE). This has not prevented the authorities at the National Museum in New Delhi from listing the bronzes